to the fore and India contemplated retaliation.[89] India's failure to resort to force in the wake of this attack remains a critical puzzle. Admittedly, Pakistan's forces had been on alert since the Indian mobilization in January. But given the brazenness of this attack and the popular pressures on a jingoistic regime, its failure to resort to military action cannot be casually dismissed.[90] The critical factor that inhibited India from resorting to any form of military action was, even after the Kaluchak massacre, Pakistan's ability to threaten to escalate to the nuclear level.[91] As Praveen Swami, one of India's most informed journalists has written:

> In interviews with the author, two senior Indian officials involved with Operation Parakram claimed that the Vajpayee government had long been contemplating possible military responses to the post-1998 escalation of violence by Pakistan-based groups. The risk of nuclear escalation, the officials said, was important in shaping Indian policy responses. Vajpayee feared that a full-scale military response to Pakistan-backed terrorism could precipitate a wider conflagration. Although Vajpayee believed that the risk of nuclear war was small, he nonetheless saw no advantage in precipitating a crisis of which it might be an outcome.[92]

Swami's discussion once again underscores the critical role of nuclear weapons in preventing the state from resorting to war. The BJP-led regime had few compunctions about the use of force. However, faced with the possibility of nuclear escalation it was forced to exercise considerable self-restraint.

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Because the 2001–2002 crisis did not escalate to the level of combat, optimistic scholars argue that it demonstrates the stabilizing effects of nuclear weapons on the subcontinent.[93] The truth, however, is more complicated than the optimists suggest. Nuclear weapons did not play a major role in dissuading Indian leaders from